

EPFL HUMAN RESEARCH ETHICS COMMITTEE

RESEARCH PROTOCOL AND ETHICAL ISSUES - SECTION C2

This document needs to be uploaded in section C2 of the on-line HREC application form

Name applicants	Rens Chazottes and Robin Huguenot-Noël
Title project	Climate Policy and Just Transition: A Comparative Study of Worker Support (JUST-CLIP)

Please describe your research protocol, incl. study design / research methodology (e.g. observational, survey research, experimental). Give details of any samples or measurements to be taken.

Project rational and research questions

Climate change and decarbonization imperatives have led governments across the world to adopt policies aimed at reducing the economic value of carbon-intensive assets, such as coal mines, fossil fuel-powered and vehicles, and aircraft reliant on traditional jet fuel. Decarbonisation policies, however, rarely affect asset holders alone. More often than not, the ‘stranding’ of such assets comes at a cost for the social fabric of established communities – from the fragmentation of local social structures to the contestation of democratic structures by anti-climate parties (as observed in the US, Argentina, or the Netherlands). From a political economy perspective, this context raises two major questions:

1. Can carbon-intensive asset-stranding policies be designed in a way that enhances (rather than undermines) local community ties?
2. To what extent can political intermediaries (such as trade unions) embedded in these sectors initiate, cope with, and react to large-scale shifts in relative valuations?

Study population and sampling method

To answer these questions, we field survey experiments with workers from sectors likely to be significantly affected by decarbonization efforts: manufacturing, heavy industry (including chemicals and materials), the automobile, and the aviation sector. We conduct a comparative study of multiple European countries including France, Germany, Pologne, Italy, and Spain where unions play distinct roles in the bargaining process.

Overall, we aim to recruit a sample of 1,500 workers from industries likely to be impacted by the climate transition in each country. To do so we will undertake a snowballing procedure contacting the main unions and employers in each sector asking to share our survey with their workers.

The survey will be administered online via the Qualtrics platform and distributed through union and employer networks in the targeted sectors. To encourage participation, the survey will include an incentive: respondents will be entered into a lottery to win a €200 voucher.

We will collect participants personal information such as their e-mail address to field another survey, two months later, to understand the dynamic nature of political preferences.

Methodology 1 – conjoint experiment

A conjoint experiment is a survey method in which respondents are shown pairs of policy packages (each combining different features) and asked to choose the one they find more acceptable, allowing researchers to identify the relative importance of each feature in decision-making.

Prompt

“To address global warming, the government has adopted a five-year plan to reduce emissions in high-polluting sectors by phasing out fossil fuels. As part of this national effort, your region has been selected for early implementation of this plan. Your company is directly affected and expects to reduce its workforce by 30% over the 5 coming years. To limit the social costs of this transition, the government considers introducing a Just Transition package.

In the following task, you will be shown four pairs of considered Just Transition packages. Each proposal includes a combination of features such as the level of financial support, job retraining opportunities, investment in local infrastructure, and more. For each pair, please review the proposals carefully and select the one you find more acceptable. There are no right or wrong answers; we are interested in your preferences.”

Attributes and Levels

1. Financial compensation
 - No additional compensation
 - Lump sum
 - Monthly income bridge
2. Job support
 - No additional support
 - Personalized job support
 - Job transition guarantee
3. (Re-)training support
 - No training offered
 - Basic training (entry-level)
 - Advanced training
4. Location of the new activity
 - In your area: commute time under 30 minutes a day
 - In neighbouring area: commuting time between 1 and 2 hours a day
 - Other region
5. Community investment
 - No investment
 - Green job-creating investment
 - Local infrastructure upgrading
 - Welfare services investment
6. Union position
 - No union position
 - Union opposes plan
 - Union supports plan

Methodology 2 - vignette experiment

A vignette experiment is a survey method where respondents evaluate a single policy scenario that varies systematically across different respondents, allowing researchers to assess how changes in

specific elements of the scenario influence attitudes or judgments.

Prompt

“To address global warming, the government has adopted a five-year plan to reduce emissions in high-polluting sectors by phasing out fossil fuels. As part of this national effort, your region has been selected for early implementation of this plan. Your company is directly affected and expects to reduce its workforce by 30% over the 5 coming years. To limit the social costs of this transition, the government considers introducing a Just Transition package.

FACTOR 1 + FACTOR 2

Factors

FACTOR 1 (policy design):

- Level 1 – Workers-oriented support: “While the plan is still under development, it is expected to include some form of direct financial compensation and job guarantees for affected workers.”
- Level 2 – Community-oriented support: “While the plan is still under development, it is expected to include some form of public investment in local infrastructure, schools, and healthcare services.”

FACTOR 2 (Union support) will take the following levels:

- Level 1 – Union opposition: “The trade union representing workers in your industry has opposed the Just Transition package.”
- Level 2 – Union support: “The trade union representing workers in your industry has endorsed the Just Transition package.”

Measurement strategy

For the conjoint experiment we use two main dependent variable:

- Main outcome – a dummy indicating the preferred policy
- (secondary outcome for robustness check) Respondents are asked to determine how strongly they feel about their preference from 1-3.

For the vignette experiment, we use the following dependent variables

- Main outcome - How much do you support such a policy? 0 = Strongly oppose, 10 = Strongly support
- Secondary outcome: How much do you support the following groups: a) the government, b) the unions? 10-points Likert scale 0 = Strongly oppose, 10 = Strongly support
- Mechanism - To what extent does the union’s position increase your trust in the fairness of this policy? 0 = Strongly oppose, 10 = Strongly support
- Open-ended follow up - In your own words, why does the union’s position influence—or not influence—your view of this policy? Optional text entry
- Impact on unions’ credibility - To what extent does the union’s position make you more or less likely to see unions as effective actors in shaping climate policy? 0 = Strongly oppose, 10 = Strongly support
- Impact on unions’ action - How likely would you be to attend a union meeting about this transition plan? 0 = Strongly oppose, 10 = Strongly support

Other survey items

Our survey includes questions regarding socio-demographic characteristics, political affiliation and opinions, political activities, relationships with unions and opinions towards unions, job security.

Please describe the ethical issues linked to your research project and how they will be addressed.

Ethical issues

The survey targets workers in sectors directly impacted by climate policy (e.g., coal, heavy industry, aviation), that is: groups that may face real job losses or political marginalization. Given the personal and professional risks associated with expressing opinions about union positions, government policies, or company practices, any breach of confidentiality could harm participants' employment status, union relationships, or community standing.

Mitigation strategy

1. Informed Consent: Participants will be presented with a clear and comprehensive informed consent form at the beginning of the online survey. The form will explain the purpose of the study, the nature of the tasks involved, and the expected duration of participation. It will emphasize that participation is entirely voluntary and that respondents may withdraw at any time without explanation or penalty. The consent form will also describe the data collected, its use for academic research only, and how pseudo-anonymity and confidentiality will be safeguarded. Participants must affirmatively agree to these terms before proceeding with the survey.

2. Anonymity and Data Protection: To ensure participants' pseudo-anonymity, identifiable information (e-mail collected for follow-up survey waves) will be stored in a separate files from the data and in a password protected folder. No other personal information will be collected. Data will be stored securely on encrypted servers compliant with GDPR and institutional data protection protocols. Access to raw data will be limited to the core research team. In all publications and reports, findings will be presented in aggregate form, and subgroup analyses will only be reported where the number of responses is sufficient to prevent potential re-identification.

3. Gatekeeper Engagement (Unions and Employers): Given the sector-specific focus of the study, the survey will be distributed through trade unions and employer networks in the relevant industries. Gatekeepers will be informed in writing that the study is independent, confidential, and anonymous. They will be asked to distribute the survey link without monitoring who chooses to participate. No individual-level responses or identifying information will be shared with union or employer networks at any point.